

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Freeze frames

Two people at the water's edge near Montrose Beach take photos of Lake Michigan and the city skyline in below-zero temperatures Friday, one of the coldest days of the year. Officially, at O'Hare, the low temperature bottomed out at minus 11. Other areas, especially to the northwest, were even colder — and even in the city, windchills hovered around minus 35. It is forecast to still feel like minus 14 after the sun rises on Saturday morning, with snow moving in during the afternoon. And there's no reprieve in sight. Temperatures will stay frigid, with lows at or below zero through at least Thursday.

CHICAGO'S ARCTIC BLAST

'EXPLODING' TREES? DON'T BE SUCH A SAP

Illinois arborists say viral social media posts exaggerate, but extreme cold can violently crack some of the more vulnerable trunks with noises so loud they sound like gunshots

By Christiana Freitag
Chicago Tribune

Chicago residents are weathering a dangerous cold snap this week — but so are the trees.

After a post on X warning of “exploding trees” went viral on social media ahead of this week's polar vortex, many people are asking: What's happening to our trees during this severe Arctic blast?

Experts are setting the record straight. Illinois trees rarely explode, but they can crack.

“Some of that's been blown out of proportion a little bit, the idea of the so-called exploding tree,” said Sharon Yiesla, plant

“When we get these (low) temperatures, it engages people. It gets them thinking about how trees survive, how they cope with their environment, and what happens when they're no longer able to cope.”

— Lake Bluff arborist
David Horvath

knowledge specialist at Morton Arboretum in Lisle.

Yiesla has been a horticulturist for over 40 years and she said she's never seen an exploding tree, although it does happen in brutal climates in northern Minnesota and Wisconsin.

In Illinois, she said, trees are more likely to experience what's called “frost crack,” a vertical fissure in tree trunks that occurs during extreme temperature changes.

In rapid shifts between warm and cold conditions, trees can shrink and expand quickly, and that stress can create vertical cracks in their bark, Yiesla said.

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Outcry defies ICE, cold

Thousands of Minnesotans protest violent incursion; some urge general strike

By Giovanna Dell'Orto
and Sarah Raza
Associated Press

MINNEAPOLIS — Police arrested about 100 clergy demonstrating against immigration enforcement at Minnesota's largest airport Friday, organizers estimated, as thousands gathered, despite Arctic temperatures, in downtown Minneapolis to protest the Trump administration's crackdown.

Friday's protests are part of a broader movement against President Donald Trump's increased immigration enforcement across the state, with labor unions, progressive organizations and clergy urging Minnesotans to stay away from work, school and even shops in Minneapolis and St. Paul.

“Roughly 100 clergy” were arrested, according to Trevor Cochlin of Faith in Minnesota, one of the groups organizing the protest at Minneapolis-St. Paul International Airport. They were protesting the involvement of Delta Airlines in the deportation of immigrants.

Metropolitan Airports Commission spokesman Jeff Lea said the protesters were arrested outside the main terminal when they went beyond the stipulations of their permit for demonstrating and disrupted airline operations. Authorities have not said how many people were detained at the airport.

Bishop Dwayne Royster, leader of the progressive organization Faith in Action,

Turn to Minnesota, Page 6

■ ICE memo reveals agency allows feds sweeping power to forcibly enter homes without a warrant, in violation of longstanding guidance on constitutional limits to government searches.
Nation & World in Business, Page 5

Senate chairs saved for, then brushed off by, Obama center

By Jack O'Connor
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — The Obama Presidential Center in Chicago plans to proudly include artifacts from throughout the former president's life and early career in the city, exploring the role his adopted home played in shaping his rise to the White House.

But officials are saying thanks, but no thanks, to evidence of his earliest electoral triumph, turning down a chance to display two chairs he sat in on the floor of the Illinois Senate while serving in Springfield.

The stately leather chairs have largely sat in storage for two decades, awaiting the chance to remind people about the nearly eight years the young South Side community organizer, lawyer and University of Chicago law professor worked on ethics legislation, bills aimed at curbing racial profiling and other matters as part of the Democratic majority in the state Senate.

But those aspirations are being dashed at the moment as officials at the Obama Presidential Center, now just months from opening in Chicago, say they aren't interested in adding the duo to their collection. The center currently has “no plans to include the chairs in our exhibit,” Obama Foundation spokesperson Erin Elzo said recently.

Turn to Chairs, Page 4

Auracast helps break barriers for those with hearing loss

Theaters, other public places install accessible technology

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

The first time Andrew Bellavia attended a live performance featuring a new assistive listening technology for people with hearing aids, he was blown away.

He had become accustomed over the years to inconsistent sound quality when using assistive listening technologies at live performances. But at a choral performance in New York in 2024, the venue used a relatively new technology called Auracast to transmit the sound directly to his hearing aids.

“It was really crisp and clear,” said Bellavia, of Woodstock, who has a consulting business related to hearing and communications. “It amazed me, and that was when I really started getting excited about where it could go.”

It's a technology that's starting to slowly



Mary Beth and Andrew Bellavia read from hymn books during a service at Grace Lutheran Church in Woodstock on Sunday. The Bellavias' church has installed a new assistive listening technology for people with hearing aids. TALIA SPRAGUE/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

spread in the Chicago area. In recent months the Marriott Theatre in Lincolnshire installed Auracast, as did the Metropolitan Performing Arts Centre in Arlington Heights. Chicago's Goodman Theatre hopes to launch the technology at performances later this month, and Bellavia's church in Woodstock has also installed it.

“We are seeing already Auracast deployment or installation in places of worship,

museums, transportation centers,” said Jill Mecklenburger, principal audiologist with GN Hearing, which makes Auracast-enabled hearing aids. “All sorts of venues have been and will be adopting this.”

The technology is a new type of Bluetooth that can broadcast to multiple devices at once. In a venue with Auracast, a

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TODAY'S
WEATHER



High 10 Low 6

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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